

Chasing the World Cup dream, with a pitstop in India

Last year was a seminal year for Nepal as it achieved several milestones, including its **first appearance** in the Asia Cup, the highest-ever T20I team total at the Asian Games, and qualification for the 2024 T20 World Cup.

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"Meetha mein rakh, meetha mein..."

Monly Desai's voice resonated across the Sai Meghpan Sportslife Cricket Ground on a blistering April afternoon. Sitting atop a heavy roller, Desai closely observed the Nepal cricketers as they endured the searing heat, honing their skills in the nets.

Each time Dipendra Singh Airee or captain Rohit Paudel faced the local net bowlers, head coach Desai asked them to find the elusive sweet spot. Adding an element of fun to the rigorous training, Desai rewarded good defensive shots with imaginary cash, while poor shots incurred demerit points.

Away from the urban bustle, the Nepal cricketers camped at the scenic facility in Vapi, an industrial town in Gujarat, for a fortnight. Their objective: preparation for the T20 World Cup and the ACC Premier Cup in Oman. During this period, they also participated in the Friendship



THE NEPAL PLAYERS PLAN ON REACHING THE US BY MID-MAY. WHILE THE CONDITIONS WILL POSE CHALLENGES AND THE OPPONENTS WILL BE FORMIDABLE, NEPAL ENTERS THE FRAY ARMED WITH SELF-BELIEF



Cup, a T20 tournament, alongside domestic teams from Baroda and Gujarat, ultimately clinching the title.

Amid a sea of fans, predominantly students from various universities across Gujarat, cheering on the Nepal team, the players focused on the task at hand — the T20 World Cup. "We are a determined lot, and our ambition is to achieve more for Nepal," said captain Paudel with a smile.

At just 21, Paudel, hailing from Nawalparasi district in the Lumbini province, will lead a youthful squad



at the T20 World Cup, commencing with its first match on June 4 against the Netherlands in Texas. "The more we play, the better it will be for us," emphasised Paudel.

Their dedication has borne fruit in Nepal's recent successes. Since its reinstatement in 2019 after a three-year suspension, the Cricket Association of Nepal has been proactive in nurturing the sport nationwide and discovering